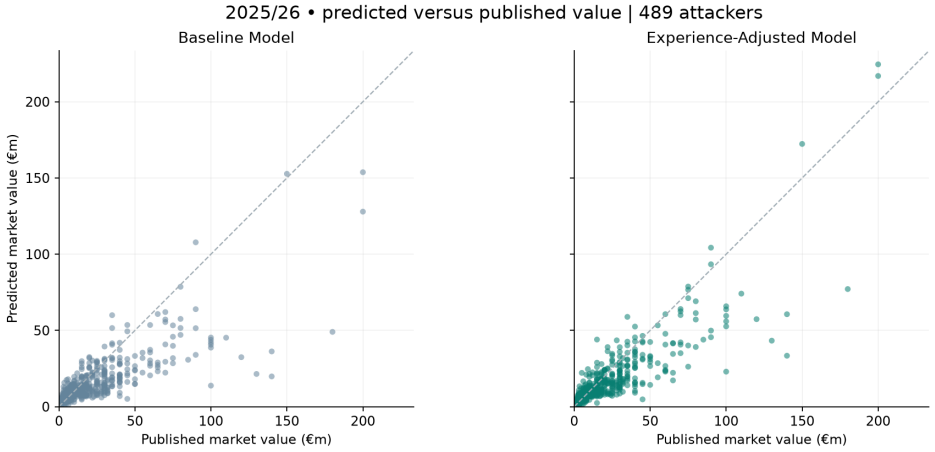
What is an attacker worth?

Performance, prior experience and published market value

The initial **Baseline Model** uses current-season attacking performance and player context. Its errors suggested that established high-value players were sometimes underestimated. **Experience-Adjusted Model** tests whether recorded high-level experience improves the estimates, without using previous market value.

2025/26 evaluation	Baseline Model	Experience-Adjusted Model
Mean absolute error	EUR 10.39m	EUR 8.70m
Median absolute error	EUR 4.53m	EUR 3.96m

Same 489 evaluation players; 1,331 training player-seasons from 2022/23-2024/25. MAE falls by 16.3%.



The specification

Both models use scikit-learn linear regression on log value: age, age squared, log season minutes, goals and assists per 90, league and attacking position. The extension adds log(1 + prior top-five-league minutes) and log(1 + prior Champions League minutes). Prior means before the season starts.

What holds up - and what does not

The benefit persists after excluding the ten highest-value players and in two earlier-season checks. The paired bootstrap interval for the reduction in MAE is EUR 1.11m-2.33m. Bundesliga MAE rises slightly; 57.7% of players improve. Mbappe remains underestimated; Olise, Igor Thiago and Joao Pedro have larger errors.

Revised valuation selection

Take the latest record as of 19 days after season end; retain it only if positive and no more than 90 days old. A new post-season update is not required. Coverage improves, but gaps remain: Ligue 1 has 36 players in 2022/23 and Serie A has 41 in 2024/25. The notebook shows coverage under 30-, 90- and 180-day limits.

Interpretation

Some valuations predate the final performance observations: this estimates published values around season end, not strictly future updates. The 2025/26 errors informed development; an untouched final test is still needed. The bootstrap holds models fixed. Missing contract, injury and wage data, uneven coverage and incomplete careers remain limitations. Published value is not a transfer fee.

Source: Transfermarkt datasets (github.com/dcaribou/transfermarkt-datasets). See the accompanying notebook.